The Lantern in the Forest

Mira lived in a small village surrounded by a forest that seemed endless. Every evening, she helped her grandfather close the shop before walking home along a narrow stone path.

One autumn night, Mira noticed a tiny golden light between the trees. She had never seen a lantern there before. Curious, she stepped off the path and followed the glow deeper into the forest.

After several minutes, she discovered an old wooden bridge crossing a quiet stream. Hanging from one of its posts was a brass lantern. Its flame burned steadily even though there was no oil inside.

Mira reached toward the lantern, but a soft voice stopped her. An old traveler appeared on the other side of the bridge and explained that the lantern belonged to the forest keeper. It had been lost many years ago.

The traveler asked Mira to return the lantern to a stone tower at the center of the forest. In return, he promised that the village would receive good fortune through the coming winter.

Mira carried the lantern to the tower. When she placed it beside the tower door, hundreds of small lights appeared among the trees. The forest suddenly looked less frightening and more like a field of stars.

The next morning, Mira returned to the village and told her grandfather what had happened. He smiled and said that sometimes the most important discoveries begin with something as simple as following a light.